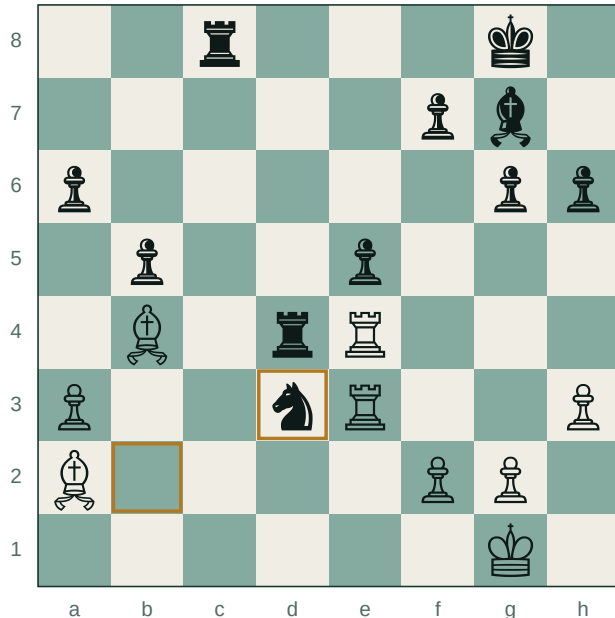


Capture the defender: White, move 32

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 31...Nd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

32. Rxd4 exd4 33. Rxd3 Rc1+ 34. Kh2

32.Rxd4 The rook captures the rook on d4. Recorded reply: **32...exd4**.

33.Rxd3 The rook captures the knight on d3. Recorded reply: **33...Rc1+**.

34.Kh2 The king moves from g1 to h2.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 14 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -2 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Absolute pin: pawn on f7.